Agent sandboxes: choose for the job, then count the bill.

For PMs, engineering leads and architects choosing where an agent cleans data, edits files or runs tests.

Model instructions → **Machine work** → **Verified result**

13 Oct 2026 snapshot: 975 retained attempts across different workloads; 12 provider specifications plus a local control. Pilot evidence, not an overall winner.

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Five categories, different jobs

Five categories, chosen by operational control

01 / Model-native
Gemini / OpenAI: execute inside a model turn

02 / SQL execution
Databricks python_exec: warehouse request and result

03 / Workspace APIs
E2B / Modal / Blaxel / Daytona: file and process control

04 / Enterprise cloud tools
Google / AWS: cloud session, identity and policy

05 / Self-operated fleets
Kubernetes / OpenSandbox: own deployment and operations

Dedicated Databricks is a workspace product, separate from SQL. Google/AWS runtime BYOC is separate from the interpreters measured here.

Categories are operational ownership models, not a ranking of isolation strength.

Evidence / methods · Residency sources · E2B rate source

Which job are you building?

Fix a repository

Keep files across calls, run tests, recover after mistakes.

Trial candidates: E2B / Modal

Clean a data export

Upload bytes, compute checked totals, return an artifact.

E2B / Modal / Google default code

Run a GPU workload

Reserve a device, choose image, test interruptions and placement.

Documented options: Modal / Daytona

Operate your own fleet

Own routing, isolation, capacity, storage and cleanup.

Documented routes: K8s / OpenSandbox

GPU and attested remote self-hosted configurations were not benchmarked. Model-native tools may fit a calculation inside a model turn; SQL tools may fit a warehouse query.

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A workflow shortlist, with the checks beside it.

Tested path	Binary return	CSV pipeline	Offline wheel	Files across calls	Error recovery
E2B	5/5	5/5	5/5	5/5	5/5
Modal	5/5	5/5	5/5	5/5	5/5
Google default code	5/5	5/5	5/5	Not established	Not established

E2B and Modal have positive evidence across these five operations. Google passed the first three through the tested one-shot path.

Each linked cell is a separate recorded setup/cohort. Five passes are a pilot signal (Wilson 95% lower bound ≈56.6%), not an SLA. Google offline install: one uploaded pure-Python wheel into a private target.

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API success can return incomplete output

Did the agent receive the complete output?

Expected: 131,072 UTF-8 bytes, including the final newline



Snapshot 13 Oct 2026 · Specific setups / pilot cohorts · See linked raw evidence

Why a PM should care: clipped structured results can be unusable; byte-exact consumers can reject a missing newline. Check what reaches the caller.

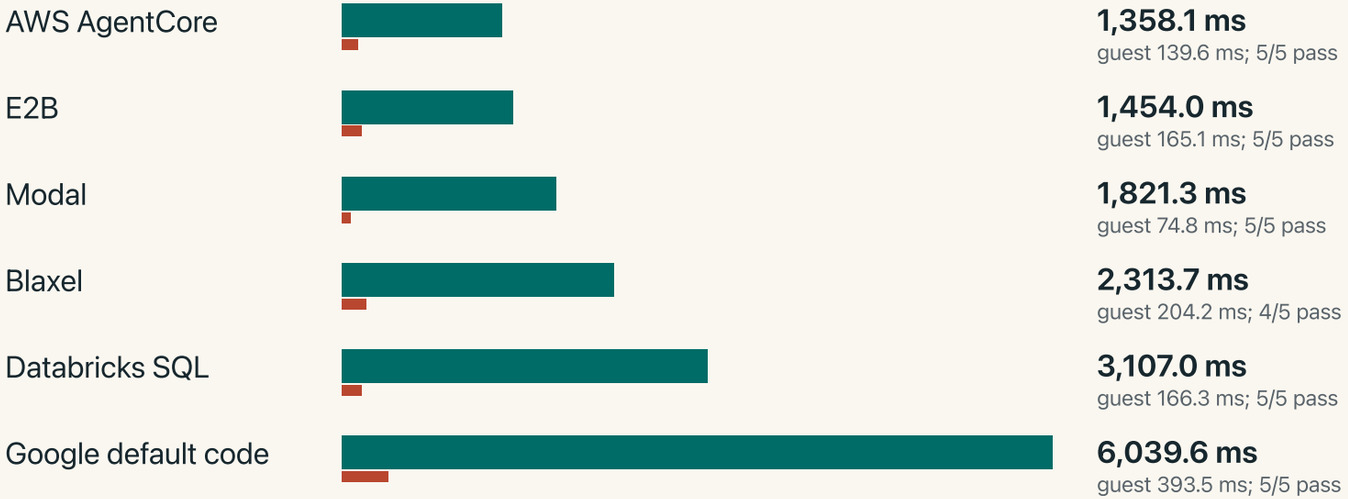
Known ordered Unicode output fixture. These findings describe stdout/log paths, not native file-size limits. No Git-patch failure was measured.

Evidence / methods · Residency sources · E2B rate source

What is the user waiting for?

Same calculation. Different user-visible wait.

Long bar: client lifecycle. Thin coral bar: guest calculation. Successful medians.



Snapshot 13 Oct 2026 · Specific setups / pilot cohorts · See linked raw evidence

The job finds 148,933 primes below two million. The caller also waits for initialization, staging, transport, collection and cleanup.

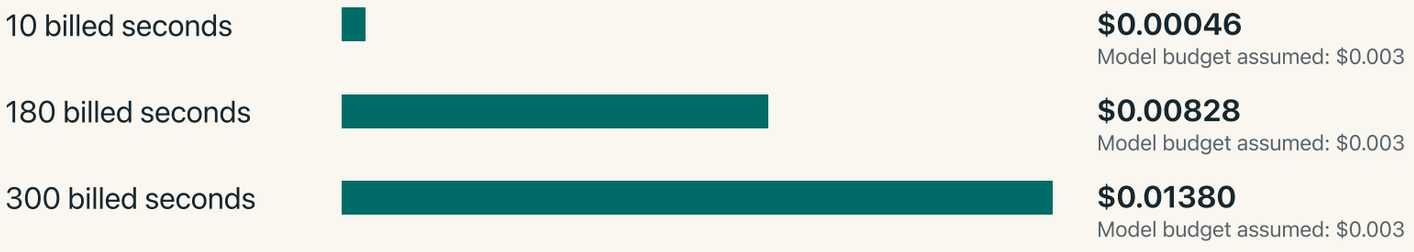
AWS had the smallest observed full lifecycle median; Modal had the smallest guest median. Different hardware, regions and clients: not an equal-hardware race. Separate final teardown is excluded.

Evidence / methods · Residency sources · E2B rate source

Duration changes the cost mix

The machine bill grows while the model budget stays fixed

Scenario: E2B published default 2 vCPU / 4 GiB; $0.000046 per billed second



Hypothetical usage, not invoices · Excludes plan fees, storage, egress, retries and tax

At 300 seconds the machine is **4.6×** the assumed $0.003 model budget. Substitute your actual model bill. Count idle wait, failed attempts and retained storage.

Model-agnostic scenario using 13 Oct list rates, not measured invoices. Gross cost per verified completion = full campaign cost / completed tasks. Zero completions means no finite ratio.

Evidence / methods · Residency sources · E2B rate source

EU compute is one part of the map

One region selector. Six data surfaces.

01 / Compute
Where code runs and data is processed

02 / Stored copies
Files, volumes, images, snapshots and backups

03 / Logs / traces
What stdout, stderr and telemetry retain

04 / Control plane
Account data and lifecycle metadata

05 / Support / subprocessors
Who can access data, and from where

06 / Model / API calls
Where the next service processes the payload

Example: Modal documents EEA compute pinning with US logs/snapshots/managed durable storage. Daytona shared GPUs ignore geographic preference.

GDPR does not impose blanket EU-only hosting. Contractual requirements may be stricter. EEA, EU-27, UK and Switzerland are distinct boundaries; other surfaces may remain unverified.

Evidence / methods · Residency sources · E2B rate source

What survives when compute stops?

Files, disk and memory are different promises

01 / Across calls
Write data.csv now; read it in the next live session call

02 / After stop/start
Shut down compute; recover files from durable storage

03 / Memory resume
Restore variables and processes, not just files

The pilot verified files across calls on E2B and Modal. Durable disk after stop and memory checkpoint/resume need their own trials.

Daytona GPU sandboxes are deleted on stop; external persistence needs an explicit plan.

Choose the lifecycle contract before using pause/delete to save compute. A timeout response does not independently prove remote process termination.

Evidence / methods · Residency sources · E2B rate source

Take the shortlist to your own workload.

Exact attempts, provider contracts and reproduction commands are in the repository companion.

Open raw evidence →

Repository guide →

Run / contribute a cohort →

Residency sources →

A public repository destination is not configured in this checkout. Add its reviewed release URL when publishing the article or attachment.

No global vendor winner or invoice-backed cheapest-provider claim. Start with one real job, preserve failures and verify cleanup/cancellation.